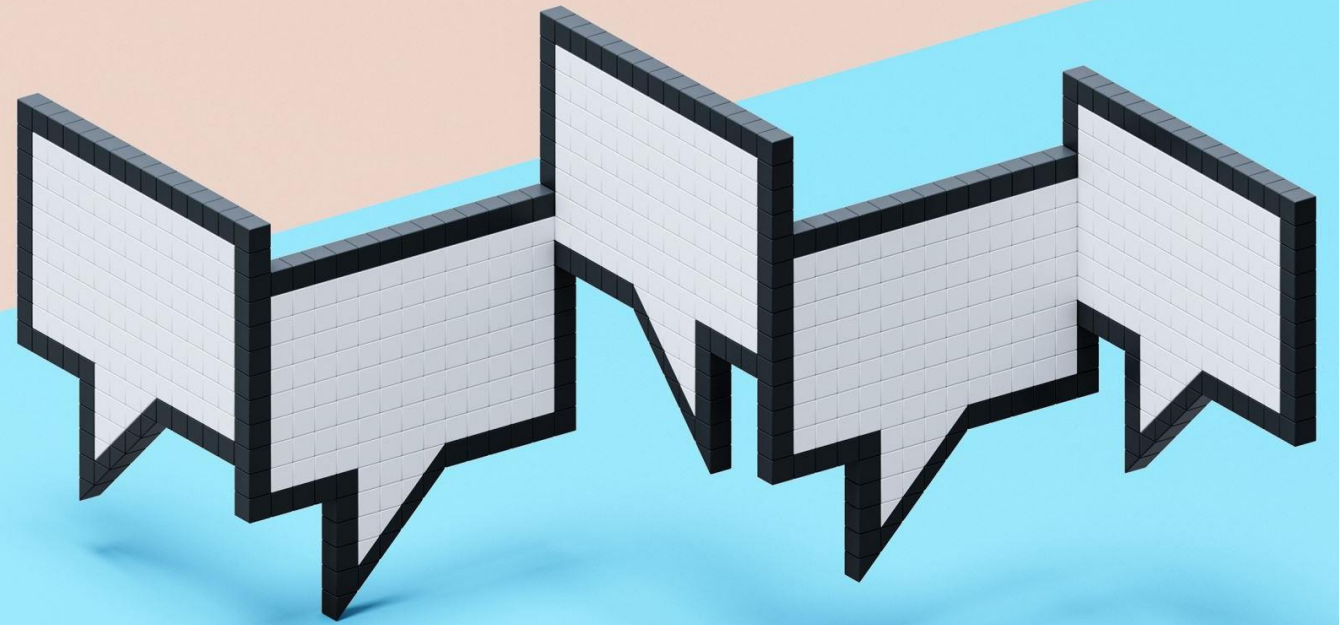
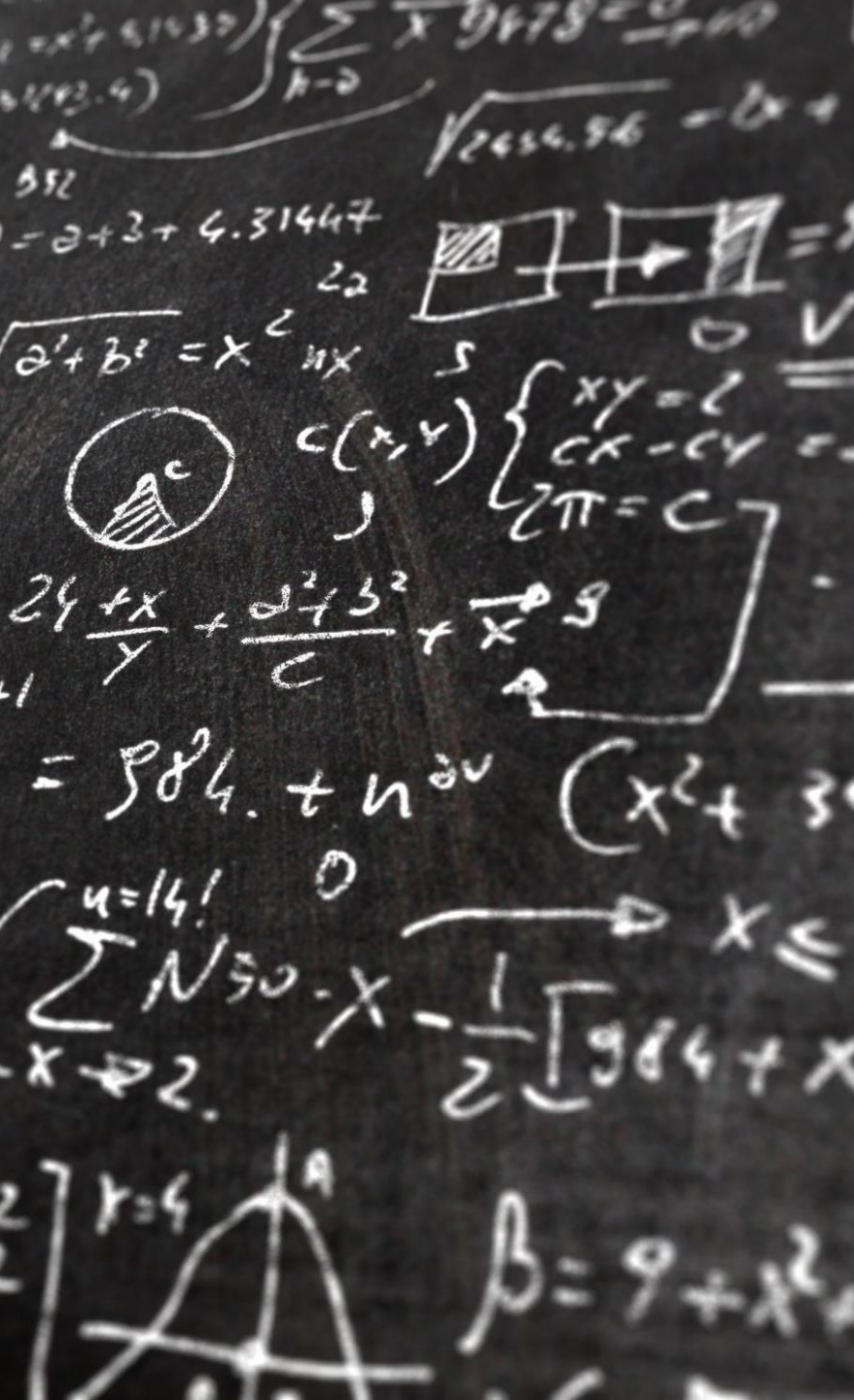

BARRIERS OF COMMUNICATION



Lecture 3

BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

- These are the factors that cause problems for communication – they hinder the clear interpretation and reception of message.
- In some situations, they are known as **blockers**. We must be aware of them if we are to overcome them or communicate in such a way as to minimize their effect.
- There are many reasons why interpersonal communications may fail. In many communications, the message (what is said) may not be received exactly the way the sender intended.
- It is, therefore, important that the communicator seeks feedback to check that their message is clearly understood.



1. LANGUAGE BARRIERS:

When communicating in the same language, the terminology used in a message may act as a barrier if it is not fully understood by the receiver(s).

For example, a message that includes a lot of specialist jargon and abbreviations will not be understood by a receiver who is not familiar. Clearly, language and linguistic ability may act as a barrier to communication. However, even with the terminology used, and expressions may be **misinterpreted** or even considered **offensive**.



2. PSYCHOLOGICAL BARRIERS:

- The psychological state of the receiver will influence how the message is received.
- For example, if someone has personal **worries and is stressed**, they may be preoccupied by personal concerns and not as receptive to the message as if they were not stressed. Stress management is an important personal skill that affects our interpersonal relationships.
- **Anger** is another example of a psychological barrier to communication, when we are angry it is easy to say things that we may later regret and also to misinterpret what others are saying.
- More generally people with low self-esteem may be less assertive and therefore may not feel comfortable communicating - they may feel shy about saying how they really feel or read negative sub-texts into messages they hear.



3. PHYSIOLOGICAL BARRIERS:

- Physiological barriers may result from the receiver's physical state: for example, a receiver with reduced hearing may not grasp to entirety of a spoken conversation especially if there is significant background noise.



4. PHYSICAL BARRIERS:

- An example of a physical barrier to communication is **geographic distance** between the sender and receiver(s). Communication is generally easier over shorter distances as more communication channels are available and less technology is required.
- Although modern technology often serves to reduce the impact of physical barriers, the advantages and disadvantages of each communication channel should be understood so that an appropriate channel can be used to overcome the physical barriers.

5. SYSTEMATIC BARRIERS:

- Systemic barriers to communication may exist in organisations where there are inefficient or inappropriate information systems and communication channels, or where there is a **lack of understanding of the roles and responsibilities** for communication.
- In such organisations, individuals may be unclear of their role in the communication process and therefore not know what is expected of them.





6. ATTITUDINAL BARRIERS:

- Attitudinal barriers are behaviour or perceptions that prevent people from communicating effectively.
 - Attitudinal barriers to communication may result from personality conflicts, poor management, resistance to change or a lack of motivation.
 - Effective receivers of messages should attempt to overcome their own attitudinal barriers to facilitate effective communication.
-

THE FOLLOWING ARE SOME SPECIFIC BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION:



(a) Differences in Perception: eg people of different ages, nationalities, cultures, education, occupation, sex, status, personality etc - each have different perceptions. Thus, differences in perception are often the root of many of other barriers to communication. Communication does not easily take place between people who have different perceptions. Eg. An employee listening to his manager talk about the importance of teamwork and its benefits but is not comfortable in the team would likely 'block' the message.



(b) Jumping to Conclusions: “see what we expect to see, hear, what we expect to hear” rather than what is being said.



(c) Stereotyping: treating all people as if they were the same. Thus, danger of discussing people and what they say/communicate. A good example is taking a whole community/religious group to be the same if there is one who has done wrong.



(d) Lack of Knowledge: It is difficult to communicate effectively with someone who has a very different background from yours, or whose knowledge of the particular subject of discussion is considerably less than yours.



(e) Lack of interest: The receiver's lack of interest in your message. Do not assume that everyone is as concerned about our interests as we are.



(f) Difficulties in Self-Expression: Communicator has difficulty finding the words to carry ideas. This also goes with lack of confidence.



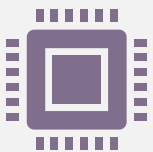
(g) Emotions: Any strong felt emotion of either receiver or communicator can also prove to be a serious barrier.



(h) Personality: Differences in people's personality can cause problems. Often our resulting behavior can then affect the behaviour of the other person eg the issue of '**clash of personalities**' is one of the most common causes of communication failure. Strong influences against personalities may make one accept or reject what is being said with due consideration.



(i) Poor Listening Skills: for example, a group/audience/receiver who is not used to sitting down and concentrating – therefore, message is not successfully communicated thus resulting in an inappropriate feedback.



(j) Information Overload: this results from giving too much details, facts in every short period of time. This would mean that most of the message would not be communicated successfully.



(l) Lack of Understanding: using 'big' words or unfamiliar words to the audience/receiver that they do not understand, words with symbolic meaning, different interpretations will lead to misunderstanding.



(m) Poor Timing: The message must be delivered at the right time. Eg. Telephoning at lunch time and Friday afternoons may make it difficult to get through because the person you need is not available.



(n) Noise: This is any sound/anything that is unwanted which interrupts a communication channel. The noise could be either: **Technical:** eg. Interference on a mobile phone or fax not working **Physical:** too much activity in the area where communication is taking place **Psychological:** increased anxiety may interfere with ability to pay attention to the other speaker.



(o) Appearance of the Individual: this may hinder communication if the audience is critical. A speaker with a **dirty** outfit/who is **poorly dressed** may not receive the favourable response from the audience.



(p) Distraction: any upsetting factor which influences the human senses such as strong light/strong smell will hinder effective communication.



(q) Mistrust: when the parties in the business of communicating do not trust one another and there is no goodwill. Effective communication will be hindered.

Unless we overcome the barriers that make us not communicate, more barriers will be created.

OVERCOMING COMMUNICATION BARRIERS

The following are some of the ways of overcoming the barriers:



(i) Face-to-Face: This will allow for constant adjustment of the message to ensure that the message is received well.



(ii) Being sensitive to the other person' /people's backgrounds. Eg. Where the person grew, tribe, culture, language and level of education.



(iii) The use of direct, simple and unambiguous language while taking care of words with symbolic meaning.



(iv) The use of frequent repetition; restatement and reinforcement/follow-up to ensure the message is properly understood.



(v) Being supportive to counter any defensive attitude – continued support will help the communication process



(vi) Being a good listener: this will encourage the communicator to continue giving the message.



(vii) Put away any mistrust, prejudice bias and misunderstanding to ensure you communicate and interpret the message clearly.



(ix) By developing interest in the subject of communication and preparing oneself for the same.



(x) By using modern technology methods which enables not only faster communication but also over great distances and geographical barriers.



(viii) Using appropriate channels of communication that keeps the noise levels low



(ix) By developing interest in the subject of communication and preparing oneself for the same.

CONCLUSION

- The above stated are only a few of the many factors which can cause communication to be less effective or even fail completely.
- It is up to the receiver of the communication/sender to make conditions as satisfactory as possible so that communication – a far from perfect process stands a chance of being effective.